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The Role of Leader Communication in Fostering Respectful Workplace Culture and Increasing Employee Engagement and Well-Being

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Abstract

Although communication is commonly recognized as an indispensable element of leadership, less is known about how leadership communication interacts with workplace respect to affect employee outcomes. We surveyed 1,512 U.S. working adults to test a model that examines the relationship of leadership communication, two types of workplace respect, and occupational resilience with employee engagement and well-being. We found that leadership communication was not associated with employee engagement and well-being; however, it was positively related to respectful engagement (generalized respect extended to employees because they are part of the organization) and autonomous respect (individualized respect that recognizes specific achievements). Leadership communication was negatively associated with occupational resilience, while employee engagement and well-being were positively associated with occupational resilience, respectful engagement, and autonomous respect. Our findings indicate that leadership communication contributes to a respectful workplace culture that then positively affects employee engagement and well-being.

Keywords

leadership communication, workplace respect, employee well-being, employee engagement, occupational resilience, COVID-19, quiet quitting

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As the COVID-19 pandemic enters its fourth year, the world's workers are reporting higher levels of negative feelings, including stress and worry (Pendell, 2022), and half of the U.S. workforce is not engaged at work (Harter, 2022a). In the era of *Quiet Quitting*, these disengaged employees are psychologically detached and unwilling to put in extra effort to meet organizational goals (Clay, 2022; Harter, 2022b). Disengagement can have a variety of negative effects on employees and organizations, including decreased commitment, performance, and well-being, and increased turnover intention, withdrawal, and counterproductive behaviors (Rastogi et al., 2018). To combat these trends, front-line managers and supervisors are being called upon to "invest effort in building relationships with their subordinates and show in their words and actions that they care about their well-being" (Johnson, 2023, p. 9). In the workplace, an employee's sense of well-being is defined as their cognitive and affective evaluations of their work life (Gallagher et al., 2009).

A primary way leaders can increase engagement and employees' sense of well-being is through building supportive workplace culture (LaGree et al., 2023). Schein (2004) defined culture as consisting of two parts: "a dynamic phenomenon that surrounds us at all times, being constantly enacted and created by our interactions with others and shaped by leadership behavior, and a set of structures, routines, rules, and norms that guide and constrain behavior" (p. 1). Research shows that supportive workplace culture is associated with a range of positive employee outcomes such as job satisfaction (Colbert et al., 2016; Schulz-Knappe & Ter Hoeven, 2023), flourishing (Colbert et al., 2016; Ernst Kossek et al., 2012), and resilience (Cooke et al., 2019). Leaders can foster supportive workplace culture through leadership communication, which Mayfield and Mayfield (2017) define as the perceived articulation of talk or action by a person recognized as a leader, and through displays of respect that provide a "behavioral manifestation of believing another person has value" (Grover, 2014, p. 28). Through their communication, leaders can help employees deal with professional issues such as shifting work demands as well as personal issues such as emotional health that might keep them from being fully engaged in their work (Honigmann et al., 2020). When leaders help employees feel respected because for their individual achievements and because they are part of the organization, employees report increased occupational resilience, job satisfaction, loyalty, and job engagement (LaGree et al., 2023). Occupational resilience, which is an employee's ability to bounce back or reintegrate after a difficult experience (Buzzanell, 2010), is especially relevant as organizations adapt to new ways of working in the re-entry phase after the disruptions associated with COVID-19 (Honigmann et al., 2020). The current study seeks to understand how leadership communication interacts with two types of workplace respect and occupational resilience to influence job engagement and employee well-being in the context of U.S. working adults. This study enhances our understanding of how leadership communication functions to foster supportive work cultures that, in turn, drive positive job outcomes and employee well-being. In the following section we review the concepts of leadership communication, workplace respect, flourishing at work, job engagement, and occupational resilience.

Literature Review: Key Concepts

Leadership Communication

Communication is not merely a medium for leadership but a substantial component of leadership (Cohen, 2004). Leaders spend as much as 70% to 90% of their workdays communicating with stakeholders (Tengblad, 2006) with the goals of influencing beliefs, actions, and emotions in the pursuit of organizational goals (Cohen, 2004). Thus, leadership communication plays a critical role in influencing the information environment of the workplace through the facilitation and management of meaning (Mayfield & Mayfield, 2017). For this study, we adopt a framework developed by Hertzsch et al. (2012) that conceptualizes leadership communication as a four-stage process model that includes: (1) communication competence (knowledge, skills, and motivation), (2) communication behaviors (e.g., interactions that result in communication), (3) communication outcomes (e.g., reduced uncertainty, shared meaning, perceived goal attainment, communication satisfaction), and (4) non-communication outcomes (e.g., job satisfaction, commitment) that are mediated by communication outcomes. The advantage of this theoretical approach, which is based on Jablin et al.'s (1994) general communication process model, is that it isolates the elements of communication rather than embedding them within broader theories of leadership. For instance, transformational leadership theory (Bass, 1998) and leader-member exchange theory (Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995) focus on behaviors that are primarily communicative, but they do not explicitly measure communicative behavior (Schneider et al., 2015).

At the heart of this process model is the leadership competence construct. Hertzsch et al. (2012) conceptualize this construct as being comprised of the interaction of three dimensions: knowledge of organizational culture and rituals regarding communication, skills to translate that knowledge into appropriate behavior, and motivation to use knowledge and skill. A few studies have examined communication competence in relation to theories of leadership styles. Flauto (1999) found the quality of the leader-employee dyad accounted for most of the variance in perceived leadership communication competence, compared with leadership style (transformational vs. transactional). In a study of transformational leadership, emotional intelligence, and interpersonal communication competence, Macik-Frey (2007) found that leadership communication competence predicted attitudinal outcomes such as satisfaction with supervisor but not performance outcomes such as organizational citizenship behavior. Madlock (2008) found that leaders' communication competence was a better predictor of employee job and communication satisfaction than leadership style. Erben et al. (2019), using Schneider et al.'s (2015) scale, sought to understand how leader and follower perceptions of leadership communication affected job satisfaction. They found that when both leaders and their subordinates perceived the quality of leadership communication as high, subordinates reported high job satisfaction.

These findings highlight the importance of studying leadership communication as a construct separate and distinct from leadership style. The evidence shows that each

influences employee outcomes differently. In addition, the findings show that leadership communication can positively affect some employee outcomes in some instances, though the effects are mixed. The current study seeks to add to this literature by studying how leadership communication contributes to workplace respect and employee outcomes.

Workplace Respect

One way that leaders can facilitate a supportive workplace culture is through modeling respectful behavior. Based on Schein's (2004) definition of culture, this respectful behavior is one of the interactions that shapes the dynamic aspect of culture. Leaders have an outsized influence on this aspect of culture because they have power, which in the leader-subordinate context is defined as their ability to influence subordinates' behavior and attitudes (Rahim, 2009). Workplace respect can then be understood as a behavioral manifestation of culture that expresses the belief that another person has value (Grover, 2014). Workplace respect is regarded as "among the most important of all social cues that employees receive from their work environment, as it validates their worth and meets universal human needs" (Rogers & Ashforth, 2017, p. 3). Although respect is important across contexts, its importance in the workplace is heightened by the fact that the leader-employee relationship is transactional. Displays of respect can signal the value of contributors and their contributions, thus boosting their self-esteem (Rogers & Ashforth, 2017). Darwall (1977) differentiated between "recognition respect," or respect shown to people based on their humanity, and "appraisal respect," which is specific to a person based on their characteristics or actions. Rogers and Ashforth (2017) called these concepts "generalized respect" and "particularized respect," respectively. More recently, LaGree et al. (2023) conceptualized the two types of respect as "respectful engagement" and "autonomous respect" and found that both were related to positive job outcomes (career resilience, job satisfaction, and job engagement) in a sample of early career employees (ages 21–34). We use these concepts of respectful engagement and autonomous respect for our study.

Respectful Engagement. Respectful engagement can be characterized as the level of respect found in an organization's culture, and it is extended equally to all members of a group. This is similar to Darwall's (1977) concept of recognition respect. Respectful engagement is cultivated and shown through the daily interactions with and relationships among team members, and it helps employees feel accepted, valued, and affirmed as part of their teams (Carmeli et al., 2015). This type of respect reflects an overall attitude that every team member is valued, and it transcends the characteristics of any individual (Grover, 2014). One way that leaders can promote this type of respect is through listening and communicative inquiry (Van Quaquebeke & Felps, 2018).

Autonomous Respect. Autonomous respect is primarily communicated by leaders (either formally or informally) through feedback and recognition of individual employees, a key leadership practice. This is similar to Darwall's (1977) concept of appraisal

respect. This autonomous respect, which is provided based on specific actions or attributes, contributes to employees' sense of pride and group belonging (Tyler & Blader, 2002). Autonomous respect varies based on individuals and settings, and it acknowledges unique achievements or characteristics through employee recognition (Rogers & Ashforth, 2017).

Flourishing at Work

When employees feel respected at work, they may experience a range of positive outcomes, including increased well-being. Flourishing is a state in which employees perceive they are successful in their relationships, are optimistic and have positive self-esteem and a sense of purpose (Diener et al., 2010). When flourishing, employees are likely to report pleasant emotions and moods and high life satisfaction (Fisher, 2014). Flourishing encompasses aspects of subjective (hedonic) well-being, psychological (eudaimonic) well-being, and social well-being (Gallagher et al., 2009). Employees who report flourishing at work believe their manager or supervisor cares about their overall well-being, both personally and professionally, and feel they are recognized and valued for doing good work (Ernst Kossek et al., 2012). Flourishing at work is associated with higher job satisfaction and performance as well as lower turnover (Hammer et al., 2009). Job engagement is considered foundational to employee well-being because it is associated with a psychological connection with their work rather than attitudes or perceptions of work characteristics (Jiang & Shen, 2023).

Job Engagement

Job engagement is a topic of interest to organizational scholars and business leaders because it predicts positive employee outcomes such as enhanced task performance and increased organizational citizenship behavior (Rich et al., 2010). Kahn (1990, p. 700) defines engagement as "the simultaneous employment and expression of a person's 'preferred self' in task behaviors that promote connections to work and to others, personal presence (physical, cognitive, and emotional), and active, full role performances." Engaged employees are more likely to positively contribute to an organization's performance (Mishra et al., 2014). This takes the form of employees who are attentive, connected to co-workers, integrated into teams, and focused on performing their roles to the fullest. Rich et al. (2010) suggest that the job performance of an engaged employee optimizes their contribution to organizational goals, both directly—through increased productivity, efficiency, and quality—and indirectly—through increased helpfulness, courtesy, and involvement in the organization. On the other hand, employees who are not fully engaged have lower job performance, which can negatively impact organizational goals such as profitability and growth (Kumar & Pansari, 2015), and are less loyal to their jobs, which can increase turnover (Andrew & Sofian, 2012; Halbesleben & Wheeler, 2008; Kašpárková et al., 2018). Rich et al., (2010), drawing from Kahn's (1990) theory, identify three antecedents of job engagement: value congruence, perceived organizational support, and core self-evaluations.

Value congruence means employees feel that the behaviors needed to do their jobs align with their preferred self-images. Perceived organizational support refers to employees' perception that they have strong interpersonal relationships that allow them to take risks. Finally, core self-evaluations refer to employees' assessment that they are prepared to invest in their role performance.

Occupational Resilience

Even if employees are flourishing and engaged, they may still face challenges in the workplace. Occupational resilience refers to an employee's ability to use strategies and processes to positively adapt to adversity (Kossek & Perrigino, 2016), and it includes communicative processes that contribute to restoration of well-being (Buzzanell, 2010, 2018). In the workplace, resilience can refer to the ability to recover from changes both negative (failure, uncertainty, conflict) and positive (change and increased responsibility) (Luthans, 2002). Resilience involves both the trait-like ability to rebound or bounce back from adversity as well as the idea of adaptation through interaction and social support (Lee et al., 2013). Luthans et al. (2006) further conceptualize occupational resilience as a psychological capital resource that is developed through professional development opportunities, bonuses, recognition, and other activities that strengthen employees' social ties at work. Occupational resilience is situated in the occupational and organizational context (Kossek & Perrigino, 2016), and as such, it is positively associated with a supportive workplace environment (Cooke et al., 2019). This leads to our first hypotheses:

H1: High-quality leadership communication will be positively associated with employee outcomes.
H1a: High-quality leadership communication will be associated with greater flourishing at work.
H1b: High-quality leadership communication will be associated with greater job engagement.

As respect is shown to validate employees' worth and increase self-esteem (Tyler & Blader, 2002), we offer our next hypotheses:

H2: Higher levels of autonomous respect will be positively associated with employee outcomes.
H2a: Higher levels of autonomous respect will be associated with greater flourishing at work.
*H2*b: Higher levels of autonomous respect will be associated with greater job engagement.
H3: Respectful engagement will mediate the positive relationship between leadership communication and employee outcomes.
H3a: Respectful engagement will mediate the positive relationship between leadership communication and flourishing at work.

H3b: Respectful engagement will mediate the positive relationship between leadership communication and job engagement.
H4: Respectful engagement will mediate the positive relationship between autonomous respect and employee outcomes.
H4a: Respectful engagement will mediate the positive relationship between autonomous respect and flourishing at work.
H4b: Respectful engagement will mediate the positive relationship between autonomous respect and job engagement.

This leads to our next hypotheses:

H5: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between leadership communication and employee outcomes.
H5a: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between leadership communication and flourishing at work.
H5b: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between leadership communication and job engagement.
H6: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between autonomous respect and employee outcomes.
H6a: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between autonomous respect and flourishing at work.
H6b: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between autonomous respect and job engagement.
H7: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between respectful engagement and employee outcomes.
H7a: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between respectful engagement and flourishing at work.
H7b: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between respectful engagement and job engagement.

Finally, we offer the following hypotheses to predict how the aforementioned factors will interact to increase employee engagement and flourishing:

H8: The positive relationship between leadership communication and employee outcomes will be mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience.
H8a: The positive relationship between leadership communication and flourishing at work will be mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience.
H8b: The positive relationship between leadership communication and job engagement will be mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience.
H9: The positive relationship between autonomous respect and employee outcomes will be mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience.
H9a: The positive relationship between autonomous respect and flourishing at work will be mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience.

H9b: The positive relationship between autonomous respect and job engagement will be mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience.

Method

To answer our hypotheses, we used Qualtrics to develop and administer an online survey. We used a Qualtrics panel to recruit U.S. participants ages 18 and older who were currently employed full-time (i.e., working 40 hr/week). Potential participants received an invitation to respond to a survey about leadership communication. Those interested in participating were asked to click a link to go to the Qualtrics platform, which provided a description of the study. If interested in continuing, participants consented to survey participation and then answered screening questions to ensure they met criteria: (1) age 18 or older, (2) employed full-time (40 hr/week) in the United States, (3) as part of an organization of at least 10 employees. The latter criterion sought to exclude participants who worked in businesses that have less formal communication practices than larger organizations (Krishna, 2022). If participants met the criteria, they began the online survey. After completion of the survey, participants were compensated with incentives for their time (e.g., entry into prize raffles, small cash rewards). Data were collected between September 27, 2022, and October 6, 2022. Overall, 1,512 participants completed the survey. The median time to complete the survey was 7 min. The study design and survey instrument were approved by the institutional review board of a large Midwestern university.

Participants

Participants were 10.4% ($n=157$) age 18 to 24, 24.2% age 25 to 34 ($n=366$), 27.4% ($n=414$) age 35 to 44, 18.7% ($n=282$) age 45 to 54, and 19.4% ($n=293$) age 55 and older. Approximately half of the participants reported their gender as male (48.5%, $n=734$) and half as female (50.9%, $n=769$), with four (0.3%) identifying as transgender and five (0.3%) declining to answer. The majority of respondents identified as white/Caucasian (63.7%, $n=963$), followed by Hispanic, Latino or Spanish origin (18.1%, $n=274$), Black or African American (12.6%, $n=190$), Asian (6.1%, $n=93$), and American or Alaska native (5.8%, $n=88$). Nine participants (0.6%) declined to identify their race or ethnicity.

As for the organization size that participants reported working for, 13.2% of participants ($n=199$) reported being in an organization with 10 to 49 employees, 12.5% ($n=189$) in an organization with 50 to 99 employees, 12.9% ($n=195$) 100 to 249 employees, 10.7% ($n=162$) 250 to 499 employees, 14.1% ($n=213$) 500 to 999, 7.9% ($n=119$) 1,000 to 2,499 employees, 5.8% ($n=87$) 2,500 to 4,999 employees, 5.6% ($n=85$) 5,000 to 9,999 employees, 4.8% ($n=72$) 10,000 to 24,999 employees, 1.7% ($n=25$) 25,000 to 49,999 employees, 1.9% ($n=29$) 50,000 to 99,999 employees, and 4.6% ($n=70$) 100,000 or more employees. Sixty-seven participants (4.4%) were not sure how many employees were in the organization where they worked. A majority of respondents (58.9%, $n=891$) reported that they supervised other employees at work.

The most prevalent industries that participants reported working in were healthcare (13.8%, $n = 209$), business/financial (9.9%, $n = 149$), retail/hospitality (9.7%, $n = 147$), computer science/information technology (9.4%, $n = 142$), and education (9.1%, $n = 138$).

Measures

Leadership Communication. Leadership communication was assessed using the six-item Perceived Leadership Communication Questionnaire other-rating version (PLCQ-OR) scale (Schneider et al., 2015). This scale is designed to measure how employees perceive the communication of their leaders. We asked participants to think of the communication characteristics of their boss/supervisor (the person they report to) when answering the questions. Example items include: "My boss/supervisor and I can speak openly with each other," "Especially when problems arise, my boss/supervisor and I talk to each other even more intensively in order to solve the problems," and "I am content with the way my communication with my boss/supervisor is going." Response options ranged from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree;* $M = 3.86$, $SD = 0.77$, $\alpha = .88$).

Autonomous Respect. Autonomous respect was assessed using a six-item scale developed by Tyler and Blader (2002). We asked participants to think of their boss/supervisor (the person they report to) when answering the questions. Example items include: "My boss/supervisor values what I contribute to work," ". . .respects my work-related ideas," ". . .appreciates my unique contributions to the job," and ". . .values me as a member of my work group." Response options were on an interval scale ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree;* $M = 4.11$, $SD = 0.74$, $\alpha = .91$).

Respectful Engagement. Respectful engagement was assessed using an eight-item scale used by Carmeli et al. (2015) that evaluates how members of an organization relate to each other. We asked participants to think of their current organization when answering the questions. Example items include: "the people I work with express appreciation and respect for each other's contribution to the organization," ". . .emphasize other employees' good qualities," ". . .speak to each other in a respectful way," and ". . . are always available to hear and listen to each other." Response options ranged from 1 (*not at all characteristic*) to 5 (*very characteristic;* $M = 3.87$, $SD = 0.71$, $\alpha = .90$).

Flourishing at Work. Well-being at work was measured using an eight-item scale that Fisher (2014) modified based on Diener et al.'s (2010) Flourishing Scale. We asked participants to think of their overall experience at work when rating agreement with statements such as "my work life is purposeful and meaningful," "my social relationships at and through work are supportive and rewarding," and "I am competent and capable in the work activities that are important to me." Response options ranged from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree;* $M = 4.05$, $SD = 0.63$, $\alpha = .86$).

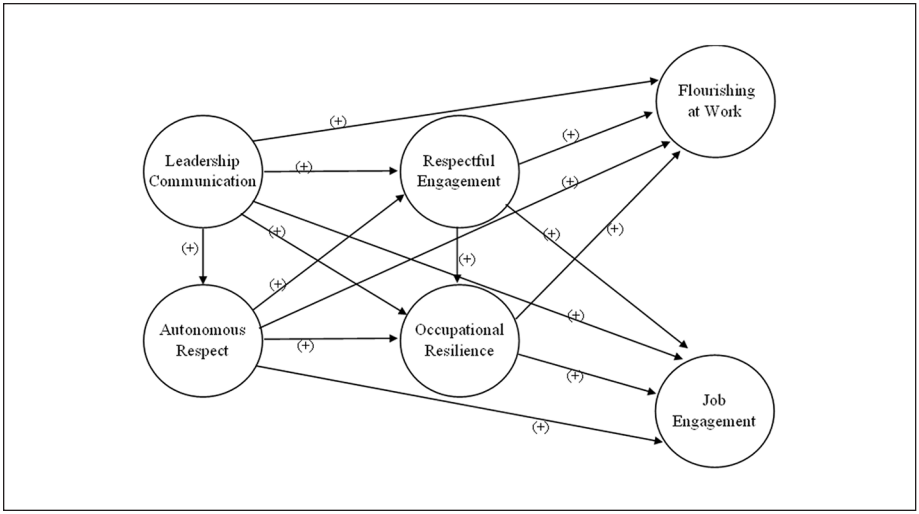

Figure 1. Hypothesized structural model of leadership communication, autonomous respect, respectful engagement, occupational resilience, flourishing at work, and job engagement.

Job Engagement. Job engagement was assessed using a 14-item scale used by Rich et al. (2010) to evaluate physical (four items, e.g., "I strive as hard as I can to complete my job"), emotional (six items, e.g., "I feel positive about my job"), and cognitive (four items, e.g., "At work, I pay a lot of attention to my job") engagement at work. Response options ranged from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree; M*=4.10, *SD*=0.64, α=.93).

Occupational Resilience. Resilience was assessed using a five-item scale based on the PsyCap questionnaire developed by Luthans et al. (2007) that is designed to measure the ability of employees to recover from setbacks. We asked participants to think of how they handle complications at work when answering the questions. Example items: "I usually take stressful things at work in stride," and "I usually manage difficulties one way or another at work." Response options ranged from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree; M*=4.06, *SD*=0.59, α=.75).

Data Analysis

Our full hypothesized model (Figure 1) was tested with structural equation modeling (SEM) using the *Lavaan* package in *R* (Rosseel, 2012). Based on the two-step process suggested by Kline (2016), we first examined a measurement model to verify whether our items sufficiently explain each latent variable in the model with a confirmatory factor analysis and robust maximum likelihood. After that, we tested a structural model (see Figure 2) with direct and indirect paths between latent variables. The model

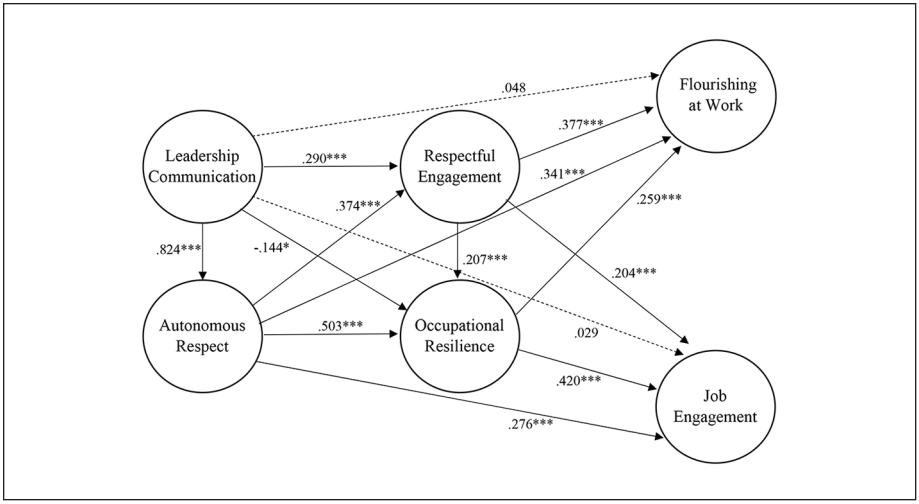

Figure 2. Structural model of leadership communication, autonomous respect, respectful engagement, occupational resilience, flourishing at work, and job engagement.
*$p < .05$. **$p < .01$. ***$p < .001$.

fit was assessed with the following criteria suggested by Little (2013): the values of Comparative Fit Index (CFI) and Tucker-Lewis Index (TLI)/ Non-Normed Fit Index (NNFI) should be greater than 0.90, and the values of Root Mean Square Error of Approximation (RMSEA) and Standardized Root Mean Square Residual (SRMR) should be less than 0.08 for an acceptable model fit.

In the process, we parceled 14 items used for measuring job engagement into three indicators because parceling has advantages to the model, such as lower correlated residuals, reduced sources of sampling error, and fewer estimated parameters (Little et al., 2002; Little, Rhemtulla et al., 2013). Four items were parceled for physical job engagement (JE1), six items were parceled for emotional job engagement (JE2), and four items were parceled for cognitive job engagement (JE3), based on the original sub-dimensions of the scale (Rich et al., 2010). In addition, we conducted inspections, such as modification indices and residual matrix, and included correlated residual variances and covariances (e.g., RE1 and RE2, RE7 and RE8, FW5 and FW6, JE1 and JE3) in the model to achieve better model fit (Kline, 2016; Little, Rhemtulla et al., 2013). Through the process, the final measurement model achieved excellent model fit, $\chi^2(575) = 1{,}409.624$, $p < .001$, CFI = 0.959, TLI = 0.955, RMSEA = 0.038, SRMR = 0.036. For each latent variable, all factor loadings were acceptable with values above 0.5 (Hair et al., 2010) (see Table 1). After establishing the measurement model, the structural model was tested with a robust maximum likelihood estimator using the 95% confidence intervals from1,000 bootstrapped resamples. The structural model fit was acceptable with the following values, $\chi^2(575) = 2{,}084.253$, $p < .001$, CFI = 0.950, TLI = 0.945, RMSEA = 0.042, SRMR = 0.036.

Table 1. Confirmatory Factor Loadings for Each Latent Variable in the Model.

	Loadings	
Latent variable	Unstandardized (*SE*)	Standardized
Leadership communication (LC)		
LC1	0.680 (0.025)	0.725
LC2	0.693 (0.026)	0.672
LC3	0.760 (0.025)	0.794
LC4	0.722 (0.025)	0.764
LC5	0.752 (0.026)	0.769
LC6	0.707 (0.025)	0.725
Autonomous respect (AR)		
AR1	0.668 (0.023)	0.811
AR2	0.754 (0.022)	0.802
AR3	0.722 (0.023)	0.811
AR4	0.609 (0.023)	0.714
AR5	0.753 (0.022)	0.81
AR6	0.753 (0.025)	0.817
Respectful engagement (RE)		
RE1	0.603 (0.024)	0.669
RE2	0.667 (0.023)	0.726
RE3	0.688 (0.024)	0.755
RE4	0.658 (0.023)	0.734
RE5	0.685 (0.023)	0.762
RE6	0.766 (0.022)	0.799
RE7	0.650 (0.026)	0.693
RE8	0.623 (0.025)	0.693
Occupational resilience (RES)		
RES1	0.487 (0.025)	0.59
RES2	0.461 (0.025)	0.555
RES3	0.481 (0.026)	0.545
RES4	0.545 (0.025)	0.662
RES5	0.572 (0.024)	0.699
Flourishing at work (FW)		
FW1	0.665 (0.025)	0.748
FW2	0.612 (0.025)	0.657
FW3	0.662 (0.025)	0.733
FW4	0.579 (0.024)	0.671
FW5	0.430 (0.024)	0.536
FW6	0.521 (0.023)	0.634
FW7	0.676 (0.026)	0.702
FW8	0.501 (0.024)	0.615
Job engagement (JE)		
JE1	0.492 (0.022)	0.734
JE2	0.710 (0.020)	0.92
JE3	0.518 (0.022)	0.733

Table 2. Results of Indirect Paths for Flourishing at Work and Job Engagement.

	1,000 Bootstrapping resamples			
Indirect path	*B*	*SE*	β	CI
LC > RE > FW	0.205	0.050	.109***	[0.120, 0.312]
AR > RE > FW	0.150	0.031	.141***	[0.094, 0.215]
LC > RE > JE	0.092	0.029	.059**	[0.042, 0.160]
AR > RE > JE	0.067	0.017	.076***	[0.037, 0.105]
LC > RES > FW	−0.070	0.035	−.037*	[−.146, −0.010]
AR > RES > FW	0.139	0.031	.130***	[0.088, 0.210]
LC > RES > JE	−0.094	0.044	−.060*	[−.183, −0.014]
AR > RES > JE	0.186	0.036	.211***	[0.123, 0.264]
LC > AR > FW	0.528	0.091	.281***	[0.362, 0.727]
LC > AR > JE	0.353	0.077	.227***	[0.216, 0.523]
RE > RES > FW	0.078	0.023	.054**	[0.038, 0.127]
RE > RES > JE	0.104	0.029	.087***	[0.053, 0.163]
LC > AR > RE > FW	0.219	0.043	.116***	[0.136, 0.311]
LC > AR > RE > JE	0.098	0.025	.063***	[0.053, 0.149]
LC > AR > RES > FW	0.202	0.045	.107***	[0.130, 0.302]
LC > AR > RES > JE	0.270	0.052	.174***	[0.177, 0.383]
LC > RE > RES > FW	0.029	0.011	.016**	[0.013, 0.056]
LC > RE > RES > JE	0.039	0.014	.025**	[0.016, 0.072]
AR > RE > RES > FW	0.021	0.007	.020**	[0.009, 0.038]
AR > RE > RES > JE	0.029	0.009	.033**	[0.014, 0.049]

Note. LC = leadership communication; AR = autonomous respect; RE = respectful engagement; RES = occupational resilience; FW = flourishing at work; JE = job engagement.
*$p < .05$. **$p < .01$. ***$p < .001$.

Results

We tested all of our hypotheses using SEM. See Figure 2 for our final structural model. See Table 2 for all indirect paths in the model and Tables 3 and 4 for all direct paths. See Table 5 for correlations between all latent variables. See Table 6 for results of our hypotheses tests.

Other Direct Effects in the Model

Additional direct effects are specified in our model that did not warrant specific hypotheses. All of these relationships were predicted to be positive in the model (e.g., we predicted more leadership communication would be associated with more respectful engagement). These additional results are presented here. While each of the predicted associations were statistically significant, one relationship was unexpectedly negative in direction.

Table 3. Results of Regression Paths for Autonomous Respect, Respectful Engagement, and Resilience.

	Autonomous respect (R^2 = .679)			Respectful engagement (R^2 = .403)			Occupational resilience (R^2 = .290)		
	B	*SE*	β	*B*	*SE*	β	*B*	*SE*	β
Leadership communication	1.454	0.089	.824***	0.375	0.084	.290***	−0.171	0.078	−.144*
Autonomous respect				0.274	0.050	.374***	0.338	0.051	.503***
Respectful engagement							0.190	0.046	.207***

*$p < .05$. **$p < .01$. ***$p < .001$.

Table 4. Results of Regression Paths for Flourishing at Work and Job Engagement.

	Flourishing at work (R^2 = .718)			Job engagement (R^2 = .585)		
	B	*SE*	β	*B*	*SE*	β
Leadership communication	0.090	0.094	.048	0.045	0.084	.029
Autonomous respect	0.363	0.061	.341***	0.243	0.052	.276***
Respectful engagement	0.548	0.059	.377***	0.244	0.054	.204***
Occupational resilience	0.411	0.062	.259***	0.549	0.068	.420***

*$p < .05$. **$p < .01$. ***$p < .001$.

Respondents who reported more leadership communication reported experiencing more autonomous respect ($B = 1.454$, $SE = 0.089$, $p < .001$) and more respectful engagement ($B = 0.375$, $SE = 0.084$, $p < .001$) than those who reported less leadership communication. Contrary to expectations, respondents who reported more leadership communication showed *less* occupational resilience than those who reported less leadership communication, $B = -0.171$, $SE = 0.078$, $p < .05$. Participants who reported more autonomous respect reported more respectful engagement ($B = 0.274$, $SE = 0.050$, $p < .001$) and more occupational resilience ($B = 0.338$, $SE = 0.051$, $p < .001$).

More respectful engagement was related to more occupational resilience ($B = 0.190$, $SE = 0.046$, $p < .001$), flourishing at work ($B = 0.548$, $SE = 0.059$, $p < .001$), and job engagement ($B = 0.244$, $SE = 0.054$, $p < .001$). Finally, more occupational resilience was related to more flourishing at work ($B = 0.411$, $SE = 0.062$, $p < .001$) and job engagement ($B = 0.549$, $SE = 0.068$, $p < .001$).

Table 5. Correlations of Latent Variables.

	1	2	3	4	5	6
1. Leadership communication	1					
2. Autonomous respect	.82***	1				
3. Respectful engagement	.60***	.61***	1			
4. Occupational resilience	.40***	.51***	.43***	1		
5. Flourishing at work	.66***	.74***	.73***	.61***	1	
6. Job engagement	.54***	.64***	.57***	.66***	.90***	1

*$p < .05$. **$p < .01$. ***$p < .001$.

Discussion

This study shows how leadership communication contributes to two types of workplace respect that foster supportive cultures, which drive positive job outcomes and increase employee well-being. This study builds upon previous research by LaGree et al. (2023) in three ways. First, it confirms the positive association of respectful engagement and autonomous respect with positive job outcomes (e.g., occupational resilience, job satisfaction, and job engagement) in a larger and broader sample (1,500-plus U.S. working adults ages 18 and older vs. 1,000-plus early career employees ages 21–34). Second, this study measures employee perceptions of leadership communication to determine the relationship of these perceptions to respect, occupational resilience, and job outcomes. The study by LaGree et al. (2023), though rooted in leadership communication theory, did not measure leadership communication. Third, this study was situated in the post-COVID-19 work environment, where employee engagement and well-being are top of mind for employees and business leaders.

Our results indicate that autonomous respect is not only associated with positive job outcomes for employees, but it is also related to respectful engagement. This means that recognition from leaders that conveys to employees an acknowledgment of their specific accomplishments not only contributes to better outcomes for employees, but also fosters a culture in which employees respect each other's contributions. This respectful, supportive workplace culture in turn contributes to positive job outcomes for employees. This result, showing a positive interplay of autonomous respect and respectful engagement, contributes evidence of the "crossover effects" of the two types of respect (Rogers & Ashforth, 2017). That is, autonomous respect not only fulfills a person's need for status but also helps increase their sense of belonging as a "bona fide member" of the group, thus increasing respectful engagement (Rogers & Ashforth, 2017, p. 1599). The results also align with past research that has linked supportive workplace culture with job satisfaction (Colbert et al., 2016; Schulz-Knappe &

Table 6. Results for Each Hypothesis.

Hypothesis	Results	Hypothesis supported?
H1a: High-quality leadership communication will be associated with more flourishing at work.	Leadership communication was not a significant predictor of flourishing at work ($B = 0.090$, $SE = 0.094$, $p > .05$).	No
H1b: High-quality leadership communication will be associated with more job engagement.	Leadership communication was not a significant predictor of job engagement ($B = 0.045$, $SE = 0.084$, $p > .05$).	No
H2a: Higher levels of autonomous respect will be associated with more flourishing at work.	Respondents with more autonomous respect reported more flourishing at work ($B = 0.363$ $SE = 0.061$, $p < .001$) than those with less autonomous respect.	Yes
H2b: Higher levels of autonomous respect will be associated with more job engagement.	Respondents with more autonomous respect reported more job engagement ($B = 0.243$, $SE = 0.052$, $p < .001$) than those with less autonomous respect.	Yes
H3a: Respectful engagement will mediate the positive relationship between leadership communication and flourishing at work.	Respectful engagement significantly mediated the positive relationship between leadership communication and flourishing at work ($B = 0.205$, $SE = 0.050$, $p < .001$).	Yes
H3b: Respectful engagement will mediate the positive relationship between leadership communication and job engagement.	Respectful engagement significantly mediated the positive relationship between leadership communication and job engagement ($B = 0.092$, $SE = 0.029$, $p < .01$).	Yes
H4a: Respectful engagement will mediate the positive relationship between autonomous respect and flourishing at work.	Respectful engagement was a significant mediator of the positive relationship between autonomous respect and flourishing at work ($B = 0.150$, $SE = 0.031$, $p < .001$).	Yes
H4b: Respectful engagement will mediate the positive relationship between autonomous respect and job engagement	Respectful engagement was a significant mediator of the positive relationship between autonomous respect and job engagement ($B = 0.067$, $SE = 0.017$, $p < .001$).	Yes
H5a: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between leadership communication and flourishing at work.	Occupational resilience significantly mediated the relationship between leadership communication and flourishing at work ($B = -0.070$, $SE = 0.035$, $p < .05$)	Yes

(continued)

Table 6. (continued)

Hypothesis	Results	Hypothesis supported?
H5b: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between leadership communication and job engagement.	Occupational resilience significantly mediated the relationship between leadership communication and job engagement ($B = -0.094$, $SE = 0.044$, $p < .05$).	Yes
H6a: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between autonomous respect and flourishing at work	Occupational resilience significantly mediated the relationship between autonomous respect and flourishing at work ($B = 0.139$, $SE = 0.031$, $p < .001$).	Yes
H6b: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between autonomous respect and job engagement.	Occupational resilience significantly mediated the relationship between autonomous respect and job engagement ($B = 0.186$, $SE = 0.036$, $p < .001$).	Yes
H7a: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between respectful engagement and flourishing at work.	Occupational resilience significantly mediated the positive relationship between respectful engagement and flourishing at work ($B = 0.078$, $SE = 0.023$, $p < .01$).	Yes
H7b: Occupational resilience will mediate the positive relationship between respectful engagement and job engagement.	Occupational resilience significantly mediated the positive relationship between respectful engagement and job engagement ($B = 0.104$, $SE = 0.029$, $p < .001$).	Yes
H8a: The positive relationship between leadership communication and flourishing at work will be mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience.	The positive relationship between leadership communication and flourishing at work was mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience (LC > RE > RES > FW: $B = 0.029$, $SE = 0.011$, $p < .01$).	Yes
H8b: The positive relationship between leadership communication and job engagement will be mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience.	The positive relationship between leadership communication and job engagement was mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience (LC > RE > RES > JE: $B = 0.039$, $SE = 0.014$, $p < .01$).	Yes

(continued)

Table 6. (continued)

Hypothesis	Results	Hypothesis supported?
H9a: The positive relationship between autonomous respect and flourishing at work will be mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience.	The positive relationships between autonomous respect and flourishing at work was mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience (AR > RE > RES > FW: $B = 0.021$, $SE = 0.007$, $p < .01$).	Yes
H9b: The positive relationship between autonomous respect and job engagement will be mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience.	The positive relationship between autonomous respect and job engagement were mediated by respectful engagement and occupational resilience (AR > RE > RES > JE: $B = 0.029$, $SE = 0.009$, $p < .01$).	Yes

Ter Hoeven, 2023), flourishing (Colbert et al., 2016; Ernst Kossek et al., 2012), and resilience (Cooke et al., 2019).

Through our examination of leadership communication in the workplace, we highlighted the effect of leader communicative acts on creating an open space for leader-employee communication and conveying that the leader cares for the employee in terms of their work and personal lives. We predicted that leadership communication would also contribute to positive job outcomes; however, our prediction was not supported as leadership communication was not directly related to flourishing at work or job engagement, the two primary job outcomes we focused on this study. Leadership communication did have indirect effects on outcomes—it contributed to more autonomous respect and respectful engagement, which in turn directly affected job outcomes. Because our leadership communication scale, the Perceived Leadership Communication Questionnaire (Schneider et al., 2015), is based on theories of interpersonal communication processes in organizations, its items predominately measure relational dynamics. Our findings lead us to believe that positive relational dynamics contribute to a respectful workplace culture, which in turn positively affects employee engagement and well-being. Future research should aim to test how different leader-employee communication dynamics affect employee outcomes.

Additionally, our results indicate that leadership communication was negatively related to occupation resilience (another job outcome of interest). This means that when respondents reported higher levels of leadership communication (i.e., open and caring communication from their manager or supervisor), they reported being less adaptable and resilient in their work. This is a surprising result and reinforces the need for further research to determine how relational dynamics affect employee outcomes. In terms of understanding this result, it is possible that leaders provide more supportive communication to employees they perceive to be less resilient. That is, leaders might communicate more concern and caring for employees seen as less adaptable and able to cope with challenges. Luthans et al. (2007) have suggested that employees who are confident in their ability to do their job well report more resilience, so the opposite might hold as well: employees who are not confident in their ability to do their job well get more leader communication and report less resilience. Another possible explanation is that open and caring leadership communication might be too general to foster resilience. In other words, if communication is not tailored to acknowledge and affirm employees based on their specific strengths and challenges, it might not contribute to resilience. More research is needed to clarify this relationship. However, this additional research should consider autonomous respect and leadership communication at the same time, as it might be the inclusion of a variable assessing autonomous respect helps illuminate the problems with leadership communication that is evident in our results.

Limitations and Future Directions for Research

This project had several limitations. Additionally, we identified several opportunities for future research in this area. In terms of limitations, our cross-sectional

survey collected data at one point in time. Future research should study the effects of leadership communication, respect, and occupational resilience over time to capture changes based on workplace conditions and adverse events at work. Additionally, variations in responses might be caused by the survey instrument rather than perceptions of respondents. We asked participants questions about their supervisors and organizations without gathering data from those sources. Future research should obtain responses from supervisors and employees and compare their perceptions of leadership communication, respect, and occupational resilience. Our data were collected through Qualtrics panel, and participants received compensation for participating. This might have affected our sample, though it is believed that reasonable compensation does not affect data quality (Jiang & Shen, 2023).

Future research could investigate the influence of work arrangements—specifically remote work or other flexible work arrangements—on communication and job outcomes. The current study did not set out to determine whether there are differences in perceptions based on race/ethnicity or age. Future research could study how employee demographics (e.g., age) affect the interplay of these variables. Additionally, organizational size may impact employee experience of leader communication, workplace culture, and job satisfaction, and this should be examined in future work. Finally, as noted earlier, future research should clarify the relationship between leadership communication and occupational resilience based on our findings of a negative relationship. Two potential theories that could be used to explore this relationship are learned helplessness and motivating language theory. The former explains how organizational characteristics, including leader behavior, can condition employee failure (Martinko & Gardner, 1982). This might explain how employees could report satisfaction with leader communication and a lack of resilience. Motivating language theory (Mayfield et al., 1995; Sullivan, 1988) distinguishes between forms of leader motivating language—meaning-making language, empathetic language, and direction-giving language—and could provide insights into which type of language affects resilience and how.

Conclusion

This study sought to understand whether and how leadership communication affects job outcomes. Although our results show leadership communication was not a significant predictor of job outcomes, it was a significant predictor of respectful engagement and autonomous respect, which are direct drivers of positive job outcomes. Our results show that both types of respect, but especially autonomous respect, are key to building respectful, supportive workplace culture. Although leadership communication is helpful for developing such culture, our model illustrates that leaders need to show their appreciation (through intentional actions, such as recognition, that drive autonomous respect) rather than just tell (through interpersonal leadership communication) to increase employee resilience and drive positive job outcomes.

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